

HORS D' OEUVRES **DILIP BOBB**

The Mobile Mistress



Physicist Stephen Hawkins says the rate at which computers are adding new intelligence, they could soon rule the world. It was an extension of the long-running Man versus Machine debate with one post script: it may already have happened.

Many of us know the symptoms but not the syndrome. I'm one of them. My mobile was stolen in Shanghai, and I experienced panic, apprehension and high levels of stress, exaggerated by virtue of being abroad.

Sanity and sim card restored, I read about something called nomophobia, derived from "No Mobile Phobia" which millions, apparently, suffer from. Psychologists describe it as the fear of being out of mobile phone contact. The term was coined during a study by a research organisation, which found that nearly 60 per cent of male mobile phone users suffer from nomophobia. The study compared stress levels induced by nomophobia to be at par with visits to the dentist. I have all the symptoms of nomophobia. Do I need to seek help or am I just being normal?

We are all now so dependent on technology that being out of constant and instant touch is like being marooned, alone, on a desert island. Another study has just confirmed our electronic addiction by identifying a new phobia called discomgoogolation! In English, it means the stress experienced at being unable to access the Internet. Computer addicts get really stressed out, the study shows, when unable to Google, hence the combo name derived from Google and "discombobulate" which means to frustrate or disconcert. The study, by British psychologist Dr David Lewis, measured heart rates and brain activity among those surveyed. He discovered that a majority of computer users were discomgoogolation sufferers.

That again is connected with Hawkins's warning about the speed of technological advance. The spread of discomgoogolation is also to do with the proliferation of broadband and WiFi which has led to computer users becoming addicted to the culture of instant access, instant downloads and instant information anytime, anywhere. Deny them that, and stress levels shoot up, found the study. "A galaxy of information is just a mouse click away and we have become addicted to the web," said Lewis. "When unable to get online, discomgoogolation takes over. It was surprising to see the stress this led to." It's yet another example of just how much machines have taken over our lives without us quite noticing. The Lewis study produced another clincher: 47 per cent of the people he polled believed the Internet was more important in their lives than religion. God help us.



SAURABH SINGH



POLL FEVER: Rajnath Singh at a rally in Uttar Pradesh

Bracing for the Big Fight

DELHI Call this the curtain raiser for the next Lok Sabha polls but both the BJP and Congress are in the process of finalising their election strategies. The BJP is holding a national executive in Bangalore, Karnataka being the only southern state under its command. It has planned over 150 rallies all over India. The BJP is also exploring new alliances with parties like AGP, INLD and RLD. It has announced a three-member committee to look into poll alliances. In addition, two other committees have

been set up to draft the poll manifesto and for the publicity work.

The Congress opted for an extended working committee in the Capital. It had already set up its manifesto and campaign committees in June but these are yet to meet. However, the party is now finalising a campaign line. It has already coined a populist slogan "*Aap hum ko vote do, hum aap ko bijli denge*" (vote for us and we will give you electricity) to cash in on the nuke deal. Round One for E-2009 has begun.

by Priya Sahgal

Just Too Much to Tender

DELHI It's raining military tenders at South Block as India's armed forces continue their shopping spree. The past fortnight has seen the army, navy, air force and the coast guard inviting tenders for close to a dozen weapons systems and airborne platforms. Worth over Rs 20,000 crore, these tenders are equal to the GDP of several small countries.

The coast guard wants

three Maritime Patrol Aircraft; both the air force and navy want Aerostat or balloon-mounted radars. The navy has floated tenders for 16 multi-role helicopters, which can carry torpedoes and missiles and operate off its warships. It also wants eight Mine Counter Measure Vessels worth Rs 6,000 crore. The organisation has also floated tenders for anti-torpedo torpedoes, the technology for which is under development.

by Sandeep Unnithan